Case Study: Aurelia Motion Systems – Task division

Opening

On a rainy Monday in March 2026, Elena Vogt, CEO of Aurelia Motion Systems, received two messages about the same AI system. The first came from the CFO and contained a short line in bold: “NOVA is finally reducing response time.” The second came from the Head of Engineering and was less celebratory: “We are spending more time correcting AI generated sales assumptions than we expected.”

Aurelia Motion Systems was a German automotive supplier with around 1,500 employees. The company produced precision components for thermal management systems, sensor housings, and lightweight assemblies for European carmakers and tier one suppliers. For many years, Aurelia had been known for engineering reliability and close customer relationships. By 2026, this position had become more fragile. Customers pushed for price reductions, electric vehicle programs were difficult to forecast, and several combustion related product lines were declining faster than management had expected.

The leadership board had launched a cost and productivity program. Sales became one of the first targets because it was visible, data rich, and slow. Customer requests often moved through many hands before a proposal could be sent. Some requests deserved intensive human attention. Others seemed routine but still consumed several days. Six months earlier, Aurelia introduced an AI supported sales suite called NOVA. The board now had to decide whether to scale NOVA more aggressively, restrict it to selected sales activities, or redesign the way work was divided around the system before making a larger commitment.

> *“We do not need a generic AI statement. We need an operating decision. Which parts of sales work should NOVA do, which parts should people do, and where have we created work that nobody officially owns?”*

Elena asked an external consulting team to prepare a recommendation for the leadership board. The consultants should analyze the evidence, and present a board level recommendation.

A short guide to terms used in this case

Term	Plain meaning for this case
NOVA	The name of Aurelia’s AI supported sales suite. It combines forecasting, opportunity scoring, and proposal drafting.
NOVA Forecast	A tool that compares customer schedules, order histories, CRM entries, and market signals to highlight likely changes in demand.
NOVA Signal	A tool that produces customer and opportunity scores. Sales managers use these scores to prioritize requests.
NOVA Quote	A tool that drafts proposal documents by drawing on previous proposals, engineering documents, customer messages, price lists, and margin rules.
Series Sales	The sales team responsible for established products and recurring business with major customers.
New Mobility Sales	The sales team responsible for newer electric vehicle, battery, and sensor related opportunities. Requests are often less standardized.
Sales Operations	The team that maintains CRM data, prepares sales reports, monitors sales process quality, and supports pricing analysis.

The sales process before NOVA

Before NOVA, the sales process was slow but understandable to most participants. Incoming customer requests were screened by a sales coordinator. A junior sales employee then prepared a first summary of the request, checked previous similar projects, collected missing documents, and drafted a first internal view of likely price, delivery time, and technical uncertainty. Senior account managers reviewed this draft and decided whether engineering, production planning, or finance should be involved. For more complex requests, sales employees called customers to clarify specifications before a formal proposal was drafted.

The process rarely followed the formal process map exactly. Experienced account managers often relied on informal knowledge. They knew which customer forecasts were optimistic, which purchasing managers sent vague requests to test supplier capacity, and which engineering contacts could clarify uncertain specifications quickly. Junior employees learned partly through what Aurelia called “messy preparation”: collecting incomplete material, making a first judgment, and seeing how senior colleagues corrected it.

Two sales teams used this process differently. Series Sales handled repeat business with established customers. Many requests concerned quantity changes, delivery adjustments, annual price updates, or replacement parts. New Mobility Sales handled requests for battery housings, cooling modules, and sensor integration. These requests were more ambiguous. Customers often sent early sketches, preliminary technical targets, or partial volume assumptions. A proposal could look attractive at first and later become difficult because tooling costs, development resources, or liability risks were underestimated.

How NOVA entered the sales organization

NOVA was introduced in three steps. In September 2025, NOVA Forecast became mandatory in Series Sales. In October, NOVA Signal was added to the same team. In November, NOVA Quote was piloted in New Mobility Sales for selected proposal drafts. Sales Operations used all three modules to prepare management dashboards. The implementation team described the rollout as “lightweight” because Aurelia did not formally change job descriptions. In practice, several employees said the work itself changed quickly.

“Nobody changed my title. But my Mondays are completely different now. I used to open customer schedules first. Now I open NOVA first and decide which alerts deserve attention.”

This comment came from Hannah Weiss, a senior account manager in Series Sales. She managed two large customers and one smaller supplier network. Before NOVA, she manually compared customer schedules with contract volumes, searched for deviations, and asked a junior analyst to check doubtful entries. After NOVA, she received a weekly list of account alerts ranked by predicted urgency. She still called customers and negotiated changes, but she no longer began with a full scan of all accounts.

For other employees, NOVA changed work less by removing tasks than by moving them. Lara Pohl, a junior analyst in Series Sales, described a typical week after the rollout. On Monday she checked whether NOVA had classified customer requests correctly. On Tuesday she corrected missing customer segment data in the CRM system. On Wednesday she added comments explaining why Hannah had overruled two AI alerts. She still joined customer meetings, but less often than before.

“The system is supposed to reduce manual work, but it also needs feeding. Sometimes I feel I now work for the queue. If a customer is coded wrongly, NOVA sends the wrong alert, and then the whole conversation starts from the wrong place.”

In New Mobility Sales, employees used NOVA Quote differently. They did not receive a mandatory weekly queue. Instead, managers could ask NOVA to generate a first proposal draft. Some used the draft as a starting point for thinking. Others treated it as a near finished document and forwarded it quickly to engineering for validation.

“When I use NOVA well, I ask it for three versions: conservative, aggressive, and technically cautious. That helps me think. But I have also seen drafts that look ready after twenty minutes, although nobody has checked whether the customer’s cooling requirement is realistic.”

Felix Brandt, a business development manager in New Mobility Sales, made this distinction in an internal feedback session. His colleague Jana Reuter saw another issue. She said that some customers had started to expect faster replies after receiving AI assisted drafts. “Once we reply within a day, the customer assumes the whole organization can move at that speed,” she said. “But engineering does not become faster just because the proposal looks faster.”

Evidence from the first six months

The leadership board received several pieces of evidence. None of them was decisive on its own. Together, they suggested that NOVA had changed the sales process, but not always in the way the original business case had assumed.

Exhibit 1. Selected sales indicators reviewed by the leadership board

Indicator	Baseline, March to August 2025	Series Sales after rollout	New Mobility pilot after rollout
Average time from customer request to first written response	5.8 working days	2.6 working days	3.2 working days
Customer requests answered within 48 hours	28 percent	61 percent	49 percent
Forecast accuracy for the next eight weeks	61 percent	77 percent	65 percent
Proposal drafts returned by engineering for major revision	18 percent	20 percent	37 percent
Average hours per week spent on CRM correction in Sales Operations	22 hours	41 hours	39 hours
Documented AI overrides by sales managers per month	Not recorded	64	18
Customer complaints about slow replies per quarter	31	13	19

The indicators created disagreement. The CFO emphasized faster response times and better short term forecasting. Engineering focused on the increase in major proposal revisions in the New Mobility pilot. Sales Operations pointed to the growing amount of CRM correction. Markus Rehm, Head of Sales, argued that the data still supported broader use of NOVA: “Every tool has implementation costs. The question is whether we redesign around it or give up when the old process complains.”

A week in the sales organization

To understand what had changed, the digital transformation team shadowed selected employees for one week. The short field notes below were included in the board dossier.

Exhibit 2. Extracts from internal shadowing notes

Employee	Observation extract
Hannah Weiss, senior account manager, Series Sales	Monday, 8:10 a.m. Hannah opens the NOVA alert list before opening her email. She marks three alerts as urgent and ignores eight. She asks Lara to check why two customers were flagged as “margin risk.” Later, Hannah calls one customer because NOVA detected a schedule change. During the call, the customer says the change is temporary and asks about a separate component not listed in the alert. Hannah adds a note manually.
Lara Pohl, junior analyst, Series Sales	Tuesday, 10:35 a.m. Lara compares NOVA customer classifications with older account notes. She corrects two duplicate customer records. She says she used to prepare first summaries for Hannah, but now “the first version is already there.” At 4:20 p.m., she asks whether she should join a customer call. Hannah says the call will be short because NOVA already narrowed the issue.
Felix Brandt, business development manager, New Mobility Sales	Wednesday, 2:15 p.m. Felix asks NOVA Quote to produce three proposal versions. He deletes one because it assumes a previous cooling module architecture. He keeps two paragraphs as useful language for the customer. He then calls engineering before sending anything. He says the tool is helpful when treated as “a colleague who is fast but overconfident.”
Mira Scholz, proposal coordinator, New Mobility Sales	Thursday, 11:00 a.m. Mira receives an AI drafted proposal from a senior manager and sends it to engineering for validation. The engineer replies that tooling assumptions are missing. Mira says the customer wanted a quick answer and the document “looked complete enough for internal review.”
Lena Hartmann, Sales Operations	Friday, 9:30 a.m. Lena reviews the weekly dashboard. She changes several data fields because sales managers entered short comments such as “customer special case” when overriding NOVA. She says the dashboard is becoming more important for board reporting, but the reasons behind overrides are often too vague to interpret.

New friction around “ready enough” work

Aurelia’s formal process map still stated that sales owned customer communication and engineering owned technical validation. NOVA made this boundary less clear. NOVA Quote could create language that sounded technically specific before engineering had reviewed the assumptions. NOVA Signal could identify attractive opportunities before Sales Operations had checked whether the underlying customer data were current. NOVA Forecast could flag demand deviations before production planning understood whether the change reflected a real market signal or a temporary customer adjustment.

> *“The document arrives with tables, risk notes, and polished wording. That format makes it feel more mature than it is. We then become the people who slow everything down, although we are only trying to find out what the draft is based on.”*

This was how Sven Richter, an engineering team lead, described the New Mobility pilot. He did not oppose NOVA. He said that some drafts were useful because they collected documents that sales had previously forgotten to attach. But he worried that a polished draft changed the burden of proof. Engineers had to show why a draft was not ready rather than sales having to show why it was ready.

Production planning raised a related issue in Series Sales. NOVA Forecast produced weekly demand deviation alerts. Planners welcomed the improved overview, but complained that the reasons behind demand changes were becoming thinner in meetings. “Before, account managers told stories, sometimes too many stories,” said Martin Gruber, Head of Production Planning. “Now they sometimes bring a score. The score is useful, but a score is not a reason.”

Sales managers also disagreed about overrides. Some saw override comments as a useful discipline. Others saw them as a burden that discouraged judgment. One senior manager said, “If I have to explain every override in writing, I will sometimes follow the system because it is faster.” Another replied, “That is exactly why we need the comment. Otherwise we never learn when NOVA is wrong.”

The board discussion

At the March board meeting, Elena asked the leadership team to focus on work allocation rather than on the general question of whether AI was good or bad. The CFO wanted faster scaling in Series Sales and a stricter productivity target. The Head of Sales wanted more flexibility and argued that local managers should decide how to use NOVA. The Head of Engineering wanted a clearer rule for when AI drafted proposals could be sent for technical review. Sales Operations wanted two additional data steward positions before any broader rollout. The works council wanted assurance that NOVA would not become an indirect monitoring tool, although this question would be discussed in more detail in a separate governance meeting.

Elena summarized the problem as follows:

> *“The same AI suite seems to reduce some work, create other work, and change when people ask for judgment. I need to know what we are actually scaling. Are we scaling better sales work, or are we scaling a faster way to move unfinished work across departments?”*

She then asked the consulting team to prepare a recommendation. The consultants would present to the leadership board.

Your consulting task

You are consultants advising Elena Vogt and the leadership board of Aurelia Motion Systems. Your group focuses on how NOVA changes the division of work. Your task is not to judge whether AI is generally useful. Your task is to recommend how Aurelia should divide work around NOVA before scaling it further. Prepare a board pitch. Your pitch should use evidence from the case and end with a concrete operating concept that the board could adopt. In particular, Elena Vogt is interested in the following questions:

1. What is the central task division problem created by NOVA in terms of automation and augmentation? Use evidence from Series Sales, New Mobility Sales, and Sales Operations.
2. What should Aurelia do next: scale NOVA broadly, restrict it to selected work, continue the pilot, or redesign the operating model before scaling? Justify your choice and discuss the main trade off.
3. Develop a Human AI Work Allocation Charter with up to five rules. Specify which activities NOVA may handle, which require joint human AI work, which remain human led, and where adjacent work must be resourced.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop this case.